

The Noble One Hundred and Eight Names of Avalokiteśvara, together with the Dhāraṇī-Mantra

Toh 874 · Derge Kangyur

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The Noble One Hundred and Eight Names of Avalokiteśvara, together with the Dhāraṇī-Mantra, is a short scripture devoted to the bodhisattva of compassion, whose name in Tibetan is Phags pa spyan ras gzigs dbang phyug gi mtshan brgya rtsa brgyad pa gzungs sngags dang. The title in Sanskrit is not given in the portion available here, so it is best described simply as a text on the one hundred and eight names of Avalokiteśvara. It belongs to the genre of dhāraṇī and mantra literature: it opens with an homage and a mantra of Avalokiteśvara, then describes how all the tathāgatas of the ten directions bless the bodhisattva and affirm the benefit of his teaching, before turning to the enumeration of his names. As Toh 874 in the Kangyur, it is preserved among the tantra-related and dhāraṇī texts of the Tibetan canon, where recitation of sacred names and protective formulas is a central devotional and ritual practice.

The Noble One Hundred and Eight Names of Avalokiteśvara, together with the Dhāraṇī-Mantra.

Homage to the bodhisattva, the great being, Avalokiteśvara.

Namaḥ sarvabuddhabodhisattvānāṃ samantāmogha apratihata śāsanānāṃ. Nama āryāvalokiteśvarāya mahābodhisattvāya vajrasattvāya vajravipulāya padmasaṃbhavāya padmayonaye. Tadyathā: oṃ hrīḥ kara śrīkara prabhākara vajrasattva vajrasaṃbhava padmasaṃbhava padmasāgara padmagocara varada mahākāruṇika kāruṇisaṃbhava hūṃ hūṃ dhara dhara dara dara vara vara mahākāruṇika mahāśuddhasattva svāhā.

Then all the tathāgatas of the ten directions extended their right hands, stroked the head of the great bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara, and declared: "Great heap of precious qualities, by expounding this dhāraṇī-mantra you have taught sentient beings the Dharma through which buddhahood arises. Excellent, excellent! Merely by hearing it, sentient beings are made utterly pure. Whoever listens to it, holds it, reads it, and masters it will attain all excellent qualities, and supreme purity as well."

Then the lord of the gods, Maheśvara (Śiva), pervading many hundreds of thousands of leagues and filling all three worlds, together with his retinue and

all the bodhisattvas gathered in the vajra maṇḍala, bowed their heads and praised the noble Avalokiteśvara with the one hundred and eight names called "Lord of the Earth, the Hero at Play":

Lord of the earth, dwelling in the vajra maṇḍala,
Lord of the great qualities of all three realms of existence without exception,
Possessor of a stainless, flawless, radiant maṇḍala,
Vast maṇḍala pervaded by compassion,
Supremely joyful, supremely delighted, supreme teacher,
Fortunate one, supreme in the peace of liberation,
Utterly pure lord of great qualities,
Flower-crowned one, renowned for many purities,
Most supreme, the single eye of the three realms of existence,
Bestower of the supreme, beauty of the wealth of all beings,
Appearing through eons beyond even the immeasurable,
Refuge and captivator of hearts, who makes all pure and clear,
Jewel-crowned one, arisen from the vajra,
Sole hero of the three realms of existence, lotus-eyed,
Ocean of learning, more heroic than all sentient beings,
Supreme one who liberates all beings,
With swaying earrings, holding a pure lotus,
Lord whose topknot is the seat of the Sugata,
Form of noble conduct, fittingly adorned with qualities,
Bearing the weapon of the great raging wind of destruction,
Cause of virtue, cause of bestowing the sublime,
Cause of the supreme great bliss, the enjoyment of the true way,
Sole cause, domain of the supreme maṇḍala,
You are the one and only bridge that ferries across the three realms of existence.
Ornament of the supreme maṇḍala, free of evil,
Who has become the support of golden-hued ornaments of light,
Through equality you become the equal of the unequaled.
Having attained the grounds, you bear garlands of ornaments of spreading light rays,
Greatness of the great, without beginning,
Dispeller of former darkness, free of afflictions,
Virtuous and pure, whose domain is utterly pure,
Whose maṇḍala, by its very way, is vast and utterly pure,

Lord of the three realms of existence, born from the lotus,
Blissful one of the three realms of existence, lord of the vast,
Unmoving lord, expert in yoga,
Great Tathāgata, most supreme and vast,
Wearing vajra ornaments with jeweled adornments,
Adorned with lotuses, arisen from Meru,
Vessel of virtue, sole vessel of great qualities,
Enjoying bliss, lord of the great guides,
Possessor of a vast ocean of aspirations,
Who liberates beings fallen into existence,
Equal to the earth, beholding all,
Light of the thousand of the Fortunate Eon,
Possessor of a maṇḍala graceful with the supreme vajra,
Dwelling in a maṇḍala pervaded by renowned qualities,
Mark of virtue, possessor of heroic prowess,
Whose domain is knowing the taste of suchness and the Dharma,
Possessor of a diadem and a circle of red tilaka,
Possessing a hundred great gods, sovereign lord of the Thirty-Three,
To whom gods and asuras, brought under control, bow down,
Endowed with a hundred diligences, possessing a thousand prowesses,
Possessing a hundred merits, holding a hundred weapons,
Hundred-lotused one, born from the lotus itself,
Beautiful at the center of a hundred maṇḍalas,
Possessing a hundred dharmas, teacher of a thousand supreme things,
Thoroughly praised by many thousands of buddhas,
Skilled through many countless eons,
Heroic body within many maṇḍalas,
Teacher possessing power that transcends the world,
You dwell at the center of a vast and stainless maṇḍala,
Supremely joyful and majestic, scattering flowers, crowned with blossoms,
Clad in garments of white silk, shining with light.
From the maṇḍala of your heart, adorned with compassion,
You bring forth fine particles of gold, boundless and inexhaustible.
Hero, you possess the hundred rays of the sun.
Your jewel disk is clear and luminous like the moon,
And you hold the supreme lotus opened by the sun.

You are renowned as the god who bears weapons of flowers.
With three topknots, son of Brahmā, Prajāpati, Lord of Creatures,
Supreme in noble lineage, you were born into a great family.
You illumine your own family, lord of a maṇḍala of great power,
Marked with the tilaka of the supreme family of the excellent lotus.
Fair-eyed one, you have become the support of the virtuous gods,
Lord who holds many secret mantras,
Sovereign of the great assembly gathered before you.
Your face is made beautiful by three eyes.
With the voice of the kalaviṅka bird you tame hostility.
You hold the arrow and the horn bow, weapons of great might.
God of strength, you tame through strength and diligence.
You are beautifully adorned with ornaments of every kind,
And praised by many Victors and holders of spells.
You are highly praised by those who perform the assembly offerings.
You fully free beings from the terror of sea monsters and crocodiles.
You have many forms and bestow happiness and joy.
Your maṇḍala is distinguished as the way to the realms of the gods.
You possess a might unequalled even by the unequalled.
Graceful in gait, supreme in great qualities, endowed with rays of light,
Wise one within the world, Avalokiteśvara,
Your maṇḍala lies at the center of the maṇḍala of the earth.
Your many thousands of rays of light are inexhaustible.
You clear away all the dust of the afflictions.
Free from extremes, you see all things.
Utterly peaceful, your domain surpasses all.
In aim and in manner, you are the one hero among sentient beings,
The sun who upholds the excellent vehicle.
You have gained faith in gentleness, generosity, and moral discipline.
You have destroyed every stain of all creatures.
Excellent in intelligence, you are the joyful Teacher.
Blissful one, you wear many light garments and ornaments.
Blessed One, you free beings from the fear of the elements.
You are the constant giver of supreme virtue.
Your mind has attained the liberation taught by the Victors.
Great source of bliss and enjoyment, you are without stain.
The maṇḍala of your face is full and stainless.

You are the supreme helping hand of humans, of Nārāyaṇa, and of Śakra (Indra).

Lord who gazes upon many worlds,

You are great in strength, in lineage, and in power.

You are equal to the Buddha, equal to the precious supreme Dharma,

Equal to the Saṅgha; free of attachment, you are hard to overcome.

Exalted in three special ways, you are equal to the great supreme Jewels.

All-pervading lord, you have cleared away the dust of the three afflictions.

Supreme Vajrasattva, to you I bow.

You hold a stainless lotus in the center of your hand.

Wearing a topknot, you bear a crown that holds an image.

The crown of your head is adorned with Amitābha. To you I bow.

Then the Blessed One, the self-arisen dispeller of darkness,

Spoke with steady voice like the sound of a great drum:

"This vajra song in praise of the great supreme one,

These hundred and eight names, which reveal and purify, have many excellences.

If anyone who always longs for supreme virtue

Offers praise to Avalokiteśvara,

That person, before long, will obtain

The Dharma, the great and supreme enjoyment of good qualities.

Whatever person always praises with this,

To them the sublime Avalokiteśvara grants his gifts.

Misdeeds will not arise in them,

And whatever they desire they will easily obtain.

They will not be stained by the defilement of misdeeds,

And will travel with their aim set upon the good highway.

Like the Lotus-Born, the sole worthy refuge of the three realms of existence,

They will engage in the supreme Dharma.

Therefore whoever wishes to accomplish the special virtues of these names,

And whoever always longs for happiness,

Should always praise Avalokiteśvara,

Lord of all beings and creatures, born from the lotus."

This completes the Hundred and Eight Names of the Blessed One, the Guru, the noble Avalokiteśvara, together with the dhāraṇī-mantra.

Translator's Notes

- "Light of the thousand of the Fortunate Eon" takes skal bzang bskal pa stong as an allusion to the thousand buddhas of the Fortunate Eon. It could also be read more loosely as "illuminator of a thousand fortunate eons." In the opening narrative, the phrase rendered "filling all three worlds" is read from an unusual spelling (rgyas ko lta ste) and is somewhat uncertain. In "Blissful one of the three realms of existence, lord of the vast," bde can might allude to Sukhāvatī; the plainer reading is kept.
 - The line rendered "the supreme helping hand of humans, of Nārāyaṇa, and of Śakra" is obscure in the Tibetan (mi dang sred med brgya byin lag pa'i mchog). Sred med is taken as Nārāyaṇa, and the sense is uncertain. The line about freeing beings from "sea monsters and crocodiles" (chu srin 'dzin khri) is likewise a best guess. "Supreme Vajrasattva" (rdo rje sems mchog) is used here as an epithet of Avalokiteśvara, and could also be read descriptively as "supreme vajra being." "Grants his gifts" (dam pa sbyin par byed) could also be read as "grants what is sublime." Prajāpati, son of Brahmā, and Lotus-Born are used here as epithets of Avalokiteśvara.
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Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.